Riichi Mahjong Strategies

Basic attack and defence

Why strategies important

- Random games
- Asymmetric Information
- Target: Increase winning chances of a hanchan
- Different rule sets requires different strategies



Levels and skills

Novice



Adept



Expert



Master



→ Know the rules

→ Focus on own hands

→ Notice other players

Levels and skills

Advanced strategies



Accurate points calculation



Advanced tile efficiency

Targeted feed

...

Nomenclature

Pin(p): circles

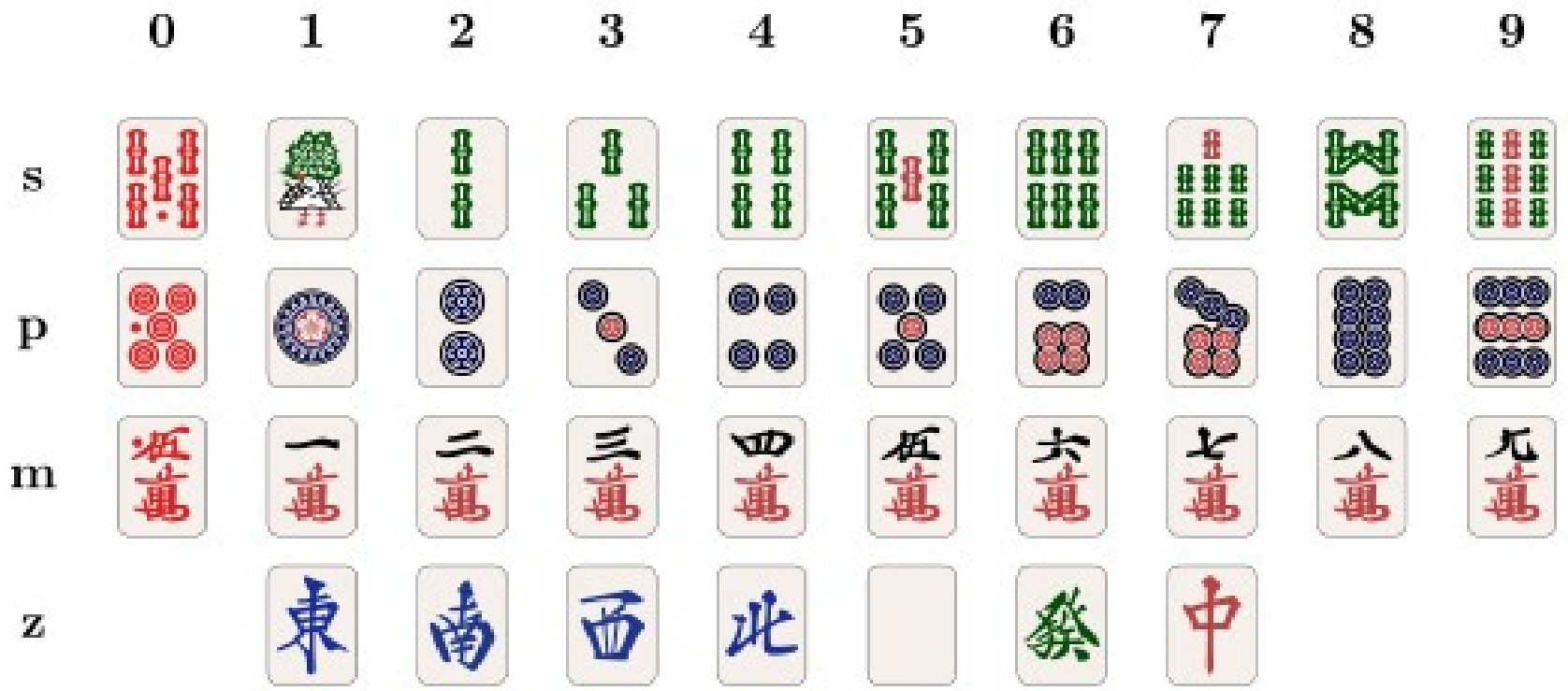
So(s): bamboo

Man(m): ten thousands



Nomenclature

表１　各タイル (麻雀牌) は、列の番号と行の文字 (MPSZ) で識別されます



Topics

- Defense
- Hand-building



Basic of all decision - Shanten

n Shanten = n-away from tenpai

Mentsu: complete set
Taatsu: two connected tiles
Toitsu: pair

Shanten = 8 - 2*Mentsu - Taatsu

(general formular)



Calculation examples



Taatsu Taatsu Mentsu

Shanten = 8 - 2*Mentsu - Taatsu

= 4

Calculation examples



Mentsu Taatsu Taatsu Mentsu

Shanten = 8 - 2*Mentsu - Taatsu

= 2

Test





Shanten - Special cases

- Chiitoitsu
- Koukushi Musou
- Other special cases
  (covered in hand building)



Defense

You never know exactly what would deal in, but in most cases you know what would not deal in!!!

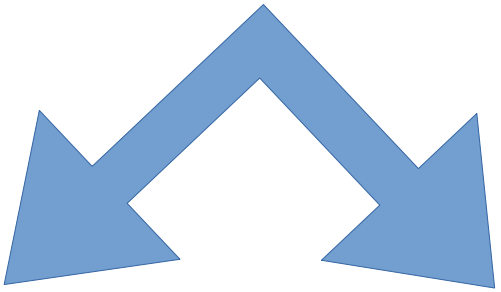


Defense - how ?

Choose tiles with small deal-in probability

Ryanmen (two-sided) is good (>50%)





Suji

Kabe
(Wall)

Defense – deal in cases

honor



1,9



2,8



3,7



4,5,6



Defense - Suji

Do not feed into Ryanmen

1－4－7

2－5－8

3－6－9



Defense – deal in cases

honor



Suji 1,9



Suji 2,8



Suji 3,7



Suji 4,5,6



half-Suji

4,5,6



Defense - Kabe(Wall)

If you can see 4 of one tile, the others cannot have it any more

Safe tiles



Kabe as safe as

Defense – deal in cases

honor



1,9



2,8



3,7



4,5,6



Defense - Safety

Table 8.5: Safety ranking

Rank	General rules
100%	Genbutsu
AAA	Fourth suji terminal; Fourth honor tile
AA	Third suji terminal; Third honor tile
AA-	Second suji terminal
A+	Second valueless wind tile; First suji terminal
A	Second honor tile
BBB	Suji 4,5,6; No-chance tile
BB+	Suji 2, 8
BB-	Suji 3, 7; One-chance tile (earlier turns)
B	First honor tile
CC	Non-suji terminal
C	One-chance tile (later turns)
DDD	Non-suji 2,8
DD	Non-suji 3,7
D	Non-suji 4,5,6



Defense - timing

- Learn to fold
- Learn not to fold easily



Defense - when ?

For beginners, pay attention to two situations

- Someone Riichi
- Someone has an mangant open hand (3 doras, chinitsu, honitsu with doras)

3 melded suit in 1. discard row

2 melded suit in 2. discard row

1 melded suit in 3. discard row



Defense - when ?

Completely fold, if

- 2+ Shanten
- 1 Shanten, less than 3 han

When fold, strictly follow the safety rank



Hand building – 5 block theory

A winning hand consists of five blocks



1 Doitsu + 4 Mentsu

Tenpai hand



4 Mentsu



2 Taatsu + 3 Mentsu

Hand building – 5 block theory

Tenpai hand



4 Mentsu

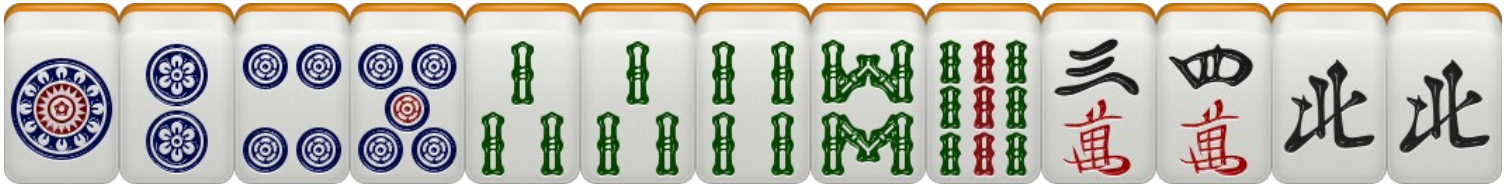


2 Taatsu + 3 Mentsu

Shanten = 8 – 2*Mentsu – Taatsu

Hand building – 5 block theory

Shanten - Special cases



Shanten = 8 - 2*0 - 6

= 2?

At most 5 blocks

Shanten = 3

6 blocks may decrease tile efficiency

Hand building – 5 block theory

Shanten - Special cases



Shanten = 8 - 2*2 - 3

= 1?

at least 1 Toitsu in 5 blocks

Shanten = 2

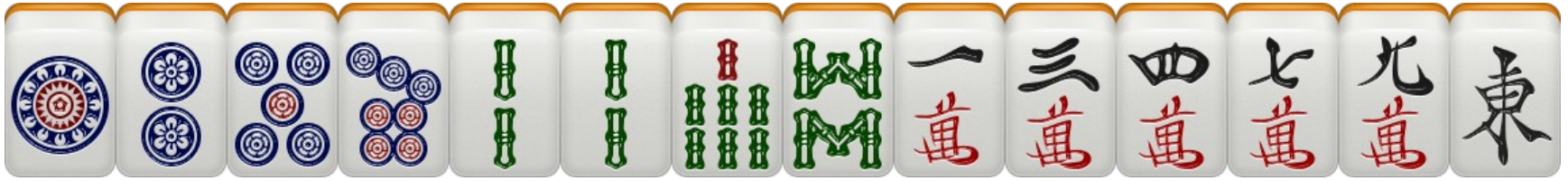
Having one pair is very important

Hand building – 5 block theory

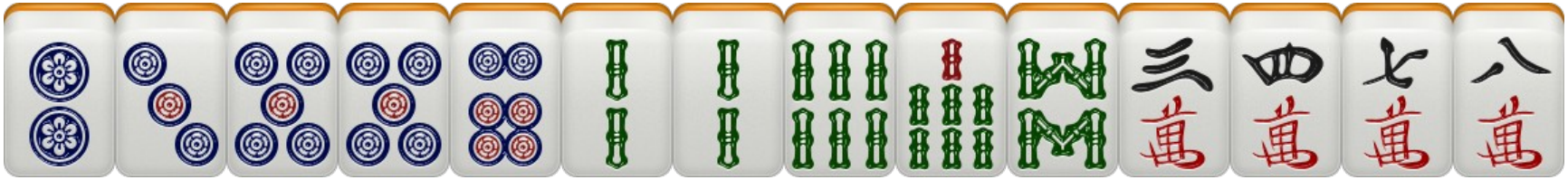
- Always count Shanten and # of Blocks (important for future)
- Never discard 3–7 if you don't have 5 blocks, unless you have a good reason
- 6 Blocks is only temporary solution in special cases



Hand building – 5 block theory



No better options, discard 1z/1m and keep 6 blocks



Discard 2p/3p to keep 5 blocks

Hand building – waiting form

Waiting form with four tiles

Tanki
(single wait)

1 kind 3 tiles



2 kind 6 tiles



Ryanmen
tanki

Shanpon

2 kind 4 tiles



2 kind 8 tiles



Ryanmen
(two sided)

Penchan
(side wait)

1 kind 4 tiles



2 kind 7 tiles



1 kind 4 tiles



3 kind 11 tiles



Kanchan
(middle wait)

Hand building – 1 shanten



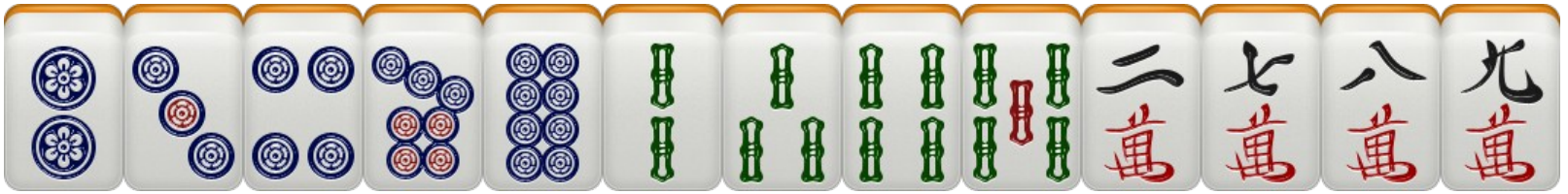
Replace one tile so that it is not tenpai, and this will be your hand. What would you choose?

Hand building – 1 shanten



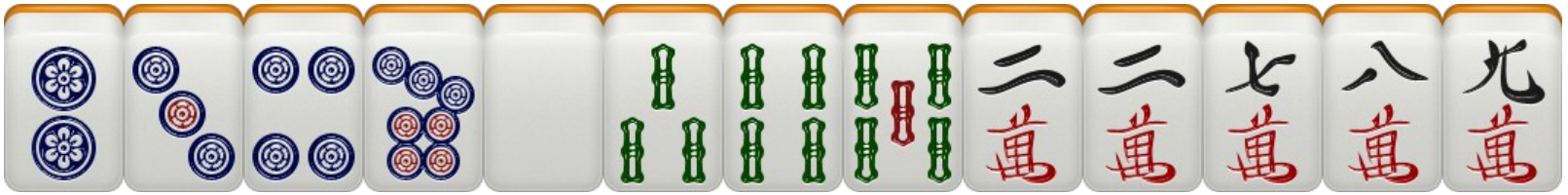
Variation 1: replace 2m







Hand building – 1 shanten



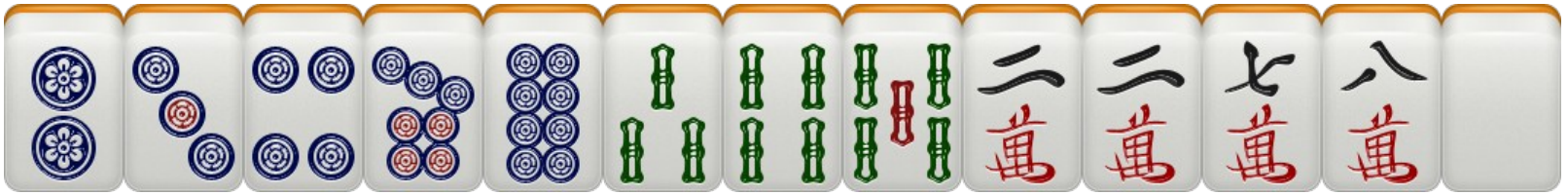
Variation 2: replace 8p





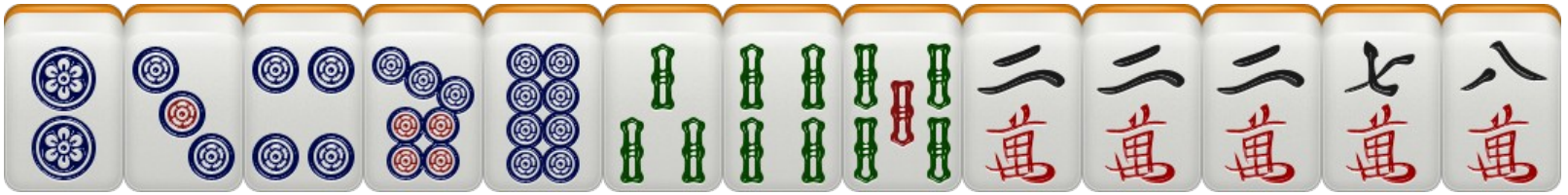


Hand building – 1 shanten



Variation 3: replace 9m (2p/4p/3s/5s)







Hand building

Most important 1-shantens

Kutsuki(2 isolated tiles)



Kanzenke(perfect), Ryanmen fixed



Atamanai(headless) with Ankou, Ryanmen fixed



How to become stronger

- learn strategy (books/videos)
- Analyze the statistics of your games
- Review the games you played
- Practice



Theme for the future

- Two pairs are strongest, three pairs are bad
- Focus on getting best 1-shanten
- Efficiency of different Taatsu
- Riichi or Dama
- Should I wait for improvement?



Some useful websites

- AI based game analysis (South only)
  https://mjai.ekyu.moe/
- What should I discard (expectation maximum)
  https://pystyle.info/apps/mahjong-nanikiru-simulator/
- Trainer (efficiency, safety tiles, ...)
  https://euophrys.itch.io/mahjong-efficiency-trainer?

